

(“Symphonie liturgique”), 1946

Paul Hindemith

1895–1963, GERMAN

Composer and musical thinker Hindemith was born in Frankfurt am Main. A gifted string player from his youth, he studied at the local conservatory and also played in several orchestras and string quartets. Surviving army service in World War I, he made his name as an avant-garde composer in the 1920s, writing chamber music for unusual instrumental combinations. He was appointed head of the Berlin music academy in 1927. Following the Nazis’ rise to power in Germany in 1933, his music was banned and he was forced into exile. He lived in Turkey, where he reformed musical education, before moving to the US in 1940. Hindemith continued to be a prolific composer, producing larger-scale works from the 1930s onward. As a teacher and theoretician, he proposed an anti-Romantic view of composition as a practical craft. He wrote music for amateurs and children to play, as well as formal works such as a set of fugues for piano. In his later years, he lived mostly in Switzerland.
